



Mara Quill

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Product Designer

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Portland, Oregon

Product Designer for complicated things: transit, robotics, and the tools behind them

I like problems that don't have an obvious screen at the end of them. Give me a bus network, a warehouse full of robots, or a support queue nobody wants to own, and I'll go find out how it actually works before I open Figma. I've spent the last decade doing that at **Halcyon Transit**, **Tidewater Robotics**, and a small Portland agency called **Paperboat Studio**, and the thing I'm proudest of is never being the designer who shipped the clean mockup that broke on day one.

These days I lead design for Halcyon's rider app and the operator tools that keep it running, which means I split my time between people riding the bus and people driving it. I write code when it gets an idea in front of engineering faster, I run my own research, and I'd rather ship something rough and true than something polished and wrong. If you want a designer who reads the support tickets, that's me.

Experience

Staff Product Designer, Halcyon Transit

2022 - Present • Portland, OR (Hybrid)

- Cut fare-purchase time in the rider app from 94 seconds to 31 by removing three screens nobody needed and one they did.
- Rode 60+ bus and streetcar routes with working operators before drawing a single screen for the new dispatch tool.
- Redesigned real-time arrival predictions after finding riders trusted a wrong ETA more than an honest "we don't know yet."
- Built the design system operators and riders now share, so a fix to one surface doesn't quietly break the other.
- Mentor two designers and run our monthly research review, which we started because decisions kept outliving the research behind them.

Senior Product Designer, Tidewater Robotics

2018 - 2022 • Seattle, WA

- Designed the fleet dashboard that let one operator supervise 40 warehouse robots instead of 12.
- Spent two weeks a quarter on warehouse floors watching how people actually reacted to a robot rolling toward them.
- Turned near-miss incident logs into a design pattern that cut false alarms by more than half without hiding real ones.
- Rewrote the robot status messages with the people who read them at 3am, which took a third of the "why has it stopped" calls off the night shift.

Designer → Design Lead, Paperboat Studio

2013 - 2018 • Portland, OR

- Carried 15+ small-business and nonprofit clients through everything from a first sketch to a shipped product, often alone.
- Promoted twice in five years and put in charge of hiring and training every designer who joined after me.
- Learned to ask "what happens if this is wrong" out loud in every client meeting, which saved at least one launch from itself.
- Kept a client's food-delivery app alive through three pivots by treating the roadmap as a conversation, not a contract.

[Earlier work and side projects at mara.example/archive](#)

Education and Recognition

- BFA, Interaction Design, Pacific Northwest College of Design
- Speaker, Cascadia Design Week, 2023 and 2025. Occasional writer on research methods for transit and robotics teams.

What I'm Good At

- **Research:** field visits, ride-alongs, and interviews over a survey when I can help it

Tools & Methods

- **Design:** Figma, FigJam, Figma Make, occasional Illustrator
- **Prototyping:** Framer, Principle, plain HTML and CSS when it's faster

- **Systems Thinking:** seeing how one screen's fix breaks a screen three steps away
- **Prototyping:** rough, fast, and disposable, built to answer one question at a time
- **Facilitation:** running a workshop that ends with a decision, not just a whiteboard
- **Writing:** specs and case notes engineers actually read before they build
- **Mentoring:** growing designers who outgrow needing me in the room
- **Research:** Dovetail, UserTesting, field notebooks, a lot of transcribing
- **Collaboration:** Linear, Notion, Slack, Figma Dev Mode handoff
- **Front-End:** HTML, CSS, enough React to prototype and be dangerous
- **Data:** basic SQL, enough to pull my own usage numbers before I ask anyone